

Pedal bass

A pedal bass is a single note repeated or held throughout a passage. In the context of organ music, a pedal is played by the feet on the pedals of the instrument, but all bass instruments will play a pedal to anchor the harmony from time to time.

▽ Bach, *Fantasia in G major BWV572*

The climax to this organ fantasia features a powerful, repeated pedal note in the bass, extending for many measures beneath quick chromatic progressions until the final cadence.



Ground bass

A ground bass is a pattern of notes repeated throughout a movement or work. Rather than the standard practice of “hanging” the harmony from a melody—like clothes on a line, in a ground bass, the rest of the harmony must fit with the ground bass. Sometimes the bass itself is the melody.

▽ Pachelbel, *Canon in D major*

This piece by Pachelbel has a two-measure ground bass and a canon in three voices above it. The ground bass is repeated throughout the piece and never deviates from a 1-4-5 cadence.



Figured bass

A figured bass uses chord symbols to indicate the notes to be played. This is used in Baroque music and in popular music, especially for guitar, both as a shorthand notation and as a way of indicating the harmonic direction of a melody, but leaving the bass player free to add notes around the chords.

▽ Corelli, “La Folia”

This arrangement of an Italian folksong is scored for violin and keyboard (harpsichord). The numbers represent the chords in the treble staff above the bass.

